



ICC

International
Cricket Council

Agenda: Developing
Strategies to Safeguard the
Future of International Test Cricket



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Agenda: Developing Strategies to Safeguard the Future of International Test Cricket

COMMITTEE OVERVIEW

The International Cricket Council (ICC) acts as the global governing body of cricket. It has 108 members, each being the cricket board representing nations or a collection of nations. Though the ICC does not have an explicit mandate, it is focused on the promotion of cricket and works in all spheres related to it. This includes reviewing playing conditions, appointing match officials for international games and organising ICC tournaments.

Another important aspect of the ICC is the preservation of the well-known “Spirit of Cricket” along with ensuring the obedience of the ICC Code of Conduct. Thus, the ICC has several cells dedicated to ensuring fair play, such as the Anti-Corruption Unit to combat Match Fixing, and the Anti-Doping Program which is compliant with WADA’s (World Anti-Doping Agency) regulations to prevent doping in international games.¹

For such units, the ICC tends to focus on enforcing the minimum requirements in international games, and provides resources to all members to apply them domestically at their own discretion. For example, their Anti-Corruption Unit Network consists of domestic anti-corruption units which have modelled their codes after the ACU’s code.

“Cricket is unique in that there are obligations within its Laws that require the captains, players and match officials to uphold the ‘spirit of the sport’.”

At its core, the ICC focuses on the development of cricket from the grassroots to the pinnacle of the

game. Thus, it falls to ICC to ensure that all stakeholders have their needs respected for a mutually beneficial outcome of promoting cricket.²

AGENDA OVERVIEW

This agenda is centred around ensuring the long-term safety and growth of Test cricket. Considered to be the purest and oldest format of the sport, test cricket has been played since the inception of cricket. However, with the rise of T20s, and consequently T20 Franchise leagues, it has struggled to stay relevant, as audiences prefer flashy, fast-paced action over the test of endurance that is Test cricket.

In this session, the committee will formulate strategies and ideas that are focused on the preservation of the legacy of Test cricket and balancing the interests of all stakeholders.

STRUCTURE FOR THE CONFERENCE

As the administrative body, the ICC has a Board of Directors, which consists of the ICC Chair, and representatives from each of the 12 Full Members and 3 Associate Member Representatives. For this conference, we will be convening a joint session of the ICC which alongside this, will also include representatives from the other ICC committees—the Strategic Growth Committee, Finance and Commercial Affairs Committee, and the Chairs of the Men’s and Women’s Cricket Committees.

For another perspective, there will also be a representative for the Federation of International Cricketers’ Association (FICA), the Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC), former and current men’s and

¹About ICC Cricket | International Cricket Council. (n.d.). ICC Cricket. <https://www.icc-cricket.com/about>

²About ICC Cricket | International Cricket Council. (n.d.). About ICC Cricket | International Cricket Council. <https://www.icc-cricket.com/about/development>

women's players, coaches, and Umpire's Representative from the Elite Panel of ICC, along with the ICC Chief Referee.

There will be several external stakeholders invited for the session, including major broadcasting partners, eminent personalities in the sport and three of the foremost T20 franchise leagues in the world.

However, the league and broadcaster representatives, the Chairs of the Men's and Women's Cricket Committees, and eminent experts will not have substantive voting rights for this session.

INTRODUCTION

Test cricket is widely known as the pinnacle of skill in cricket, yet the oldest format of the game has faced perhaps its toughest years in the last decade. With the advent of the T20 era, highly lucrative, franchise-based T20 leagues are organised all over the world, drawing eyeballs in far greater numbers than Tests, and thus forcing Test cricket to fight for its relevance.

While test cricket is still universally recognised as the purest format of the game, it faces severe headwinds, with both players and test-playing nations opting to save their best players for T20 leagues, where both players and Cricket Boards are well compensated compared to the meagre financial rewards of tests, especially outside of the Big 3 nations.³

Discussions on revitalising Test Cricket will consider four major challenges—declining viewership, financial viability, scheduling and workload Management, and a lack of

representation for Women's Cricket and Associate Member nations.

BACKGROUND

Historical Significance

The ICC was originally suggested as the 'Imperial Cricket Board', the brainchild of Abe Bailey, President of the South African Cricket Association at the time. He proposed a triangular test series between the three test-playing nations at the time, England, Australia, and South Africa, in 1909. Eventually, the body known as the 'Imperial Cricket Conference'—the precursor to the ICC—was constituted on 15th June 1909. Through its meetings, the proposal for the triangular series was accepted, though it eventually occurred in 1912.⁴

In the summer of 1926, the conference met again and changed the definition of its membership, thus granting admission to the West Indies, New Zealand, and India as test-playing nations.

From this point onward, the Conference began to move towards a more governing role, planning tours, checking the qualifications of players, and discussing matters of the rules of the sport.

At this point, test matches were played as tours between the test-playing nations, and membership remained constant for several years, until 1952, when the admission of Pakistan added another test-playing nation.

Evolution

In 1961, South Africa officially withdrew from the Commonwealth, making them ineligible for membership. Thus, South Africa ceased to be a member of the Conference.

³Mukeri, Z. (n.d.). *IPL Salaries vs BCCI Contracts: A look at how much Indian cricketers' earn*. The Economic Times. <https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/sports/ipl-salaries-vs-bcci-contracts-a-look-at-how-much-indian-cricketers-earn/articleshow/108107892.cms>

⁴About ICC Cricket | International Cricket Council. History of ICC (n.d.). <https://www.icc-cricket.com/about/the-icc/history-of-icc/1909-1963>

The Conference's evolution into the body we know today was accelerated in 1964, when for the first time, 'Associate Membership' was adopted, allowing the USA, Ceylon and Fiji to join. The next July, the ICC changed its name to the International Cricket Conference, reflecting its new global nature. Several more associates joined in the following years.⁵

In 1971, the ICC began planning its first ODI World Cup, featuring 60 overs per side.

In 1976, Kerry Packer, an Australian broadcasting magnate and owner of Channel Nine took an unprecedented step in the history of cricket. He was furious with the Australian Cricket Board for their decision to award the broadcasting rights for the Australian cricket season to the state broadcaster, a long-term partner. Thus, he went about signing over three dozen of the world's best players to create his own tournament: World Series Cricket.⁶

Similar to the T20s of today, this tournament had posed a credible threat of replacing Test cricket as the dominant format. However, World Series Cricket left lasting consequences. Players were finally paid appropriately to be full-time professionals and day-night matches gained popularity.

In 1990, the ICC adopted its current name, and gained stature as a governing body with the ability to force members to comply with its directives.⁷

In the years that followed, Test cricket continued to be played, though it had to share the spotlight with ODIs. However, its status as the pure form of the game was still intact, and thus still had

interest. However, Test cricket encountered a major setback with the introduction of T20s, which were initially dismissed by purists and cricketers alike.

Yet, with fans supporting T20s, Test cricket soon found itself relegated to being thought of as the slow, boring format in common consciousness. By 2019, the ICC acted upon the issue to prevent Test Cricket from dying out, creating the World Test Championship.

Introduction of the World Test Championship.

The introduction of the World Test Championship (WTC) was a way to enhance the relevance of the bilateral series played by Full Member nations amongst each other. Though a ranking system existed, it was merely a rolling table and all but symbolic. However, with this format, the top two nations at the end of the two-year cycle would play a final, with the winner being awarded the title of World Test Champions, a test equivalent to the ODI and T20 World Cup.

Originally, each series was allocated 120 points, distributed based on the number of matches, with all 9 participating teams out of the 12 Full Members playing an equal number of series. Thus, in a 3-match series, winning 1 match was worth 40 points; while in a 5-match series, it was worth only 24 points. A draw was worth a third of the points for winning, thus incentivising aggressive play to reduce draws. This highlighted

⁵History of ICC 1964-1988. (n.d.). <https://www.icc-cricket.com/about/the-icc/history-of-icc/1964-1988>

⁶World Series Cricket. (n.d.). ESPNcricinfo. Retrieved 2025, from <https://www.espnricinfo.com/story/world-series-cricket-72632>

⁷History of ICC 1989-present. (n.d.). <https://www.icc-cricket.com/about/the-icc/history-of-icc/1989-present>.

one of the primary complaints about Test Cricket at the time—the high frequency of draws.⁸

However, in the second WTC cycle, from 2021 to 2023, this format was changed to a win percentage system which is followed presently as well. In this system, each match is worth 12 points, regardless of the number of games in a series. It was introduced to ensure that the cancellation of games due to any reason does not result in a direct impact on the standings.

The WTC was successful in its goal of giving meaning to bilateral test series and providing teams with an incentive to compete in test matches by means of another ICC trophy. However, several gaps remain, highlighting the need for further improvements in the system. One of the major criticisms of the WTC is that, with two teams advancing to the finals, a great deal of matches at the lower ends of the table are dead rubber, as neither side have a chance at qualification. Related to this is the issue that although Test series among the Big 3, i.e. the Ashes, the Border-Gavaskar Trophy and the Pataudi/Anthony De Mello trophy, have gained prominence and viewership beyond the dedicated fanbase, the other countries have struggled to find similar interest and engagement for their matches.

Thus, nearing the end of the third WTC cycle, Test Cricket requires a significant boost to sustain its relevance and compete with the rapidly growing dominance of T20s in the cricketing world.

CHALLENGES

Commercial and Financial Challenges

Financial Appeal of Franchise Cricket

The financial appeal of franchise cricket, particularly in the T20 format, has introduced significant challenges to Test cricket. Franchise-

based tournaments like: the Indian Premier League (IPL), SA20 (South Africa's premier T20 cricket league), and the Big Bash League (a professional Twenty20 cricket league in Australia) attract massive audiences. Consequently, sponsorship deals, media rights, and player salaries are all higher. Moreover, shorter matches are more suitable for broadcasters, as they fit more easily into schedules and programming slots, offering greater flexibility.

Furthermore, franchise leagues offer lucrative careers for cricketers, tilting their interests away from Test cricket. Former Indian cricketer Dinesh Karthik specifically emphasized this financial disparity and insisted on cricket boards to ensure that Test players are compensated well. He stated that people who choose Test cricket should be financially wealthy and have sufficient opportunities to compete, as T20 is already thriving in that regard. This highlights the growing trend whereby players opt for the shorter formats because of the financial security they offer.

Additionally, the hosting and organization of franchise cricket demand relatively lower operational costs, making it another factor diminishing the financial appeal of Test cricket. Ian Chappell, former Australian Captain, said in an interview that non-traditional cricketing countries prefer T20s due to the 'prohibitive cost of developing Test venues and players. For several upcoming cricketing nations, maintaining a domestic Test structure is

⁸World Test Championship. (n.d.). <https://www.icc-cricket.com/news/everything-you-need-to-know-about-world-test-championship-2021-23>

economically unfeasible.⁹ Even established cricketing nations struggle to sustain Test cricket, considering the low returns that traditional five-day Test matches yield compared to T20 leagues, which are high-return ventures.

Financial Disparities and Revenue Constraints

The revenue distribution model of the ICC for the period 2024-27 is deemed unfair by many Full and Associate members. According to this model, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) has been given a substantial 38.5% of the ICC's annual returns, amounting to approximately USD 230 million per year, due to its significant contribution to the commercial revenue generated from the sport.¹⁰ Additionally, other Full Member nations such as South Africa and the West Indies are allocated smaller shares, with South Africa receiving an estimated USD 26.24 million, and West Indies around USD 27.50 million annually. Collectively, Full Members are projected to receive 88.81% of the USD 600 million annual pool, leaving Associate Members with 11.19%.¹¹

This imbalance of revenue sharing is worrisome for Associate members and less affluent Full

Members who fear that reduced funding could eventually make the game unsustainable in their respective countries.¹² They also believe that such a model could limit financial support for infrastructure development and player retention in Test cricket.¹³

Former South African captain Graeme Smith has also expressed the need for a more balanced revenue-sharing model to keep Test cricket alive. He pointed out that while scheduling is often the main topic of discussion, the real challenge lies in financial modelling.¹⁴ Smith has strongly advocated for a revenue-sharing model that would incentivize countries to allocate more resources to Test cricket rather than prioritizing wealthier T20 leagues.¹⁵

⁹Ian Chappell on Test Cricket | ESPNcricinfo. (n.d.). https://www.espncricinfo.com/story/ian-chappell-test-cricket-cannot-flourish-in-the-shadow-of-the-t20-format-1282205?utm_source=chatgpt.com

¹⁰BCCI projected to earn US\$ 230 million per year in ICC's new finance model. (n.d.). ESPNcricinfo. <https://www.espncricinfo.com/story/bcci-projected-to-earn-us-230-million-per-year-in-icc-s-new-finance-model-1374623>

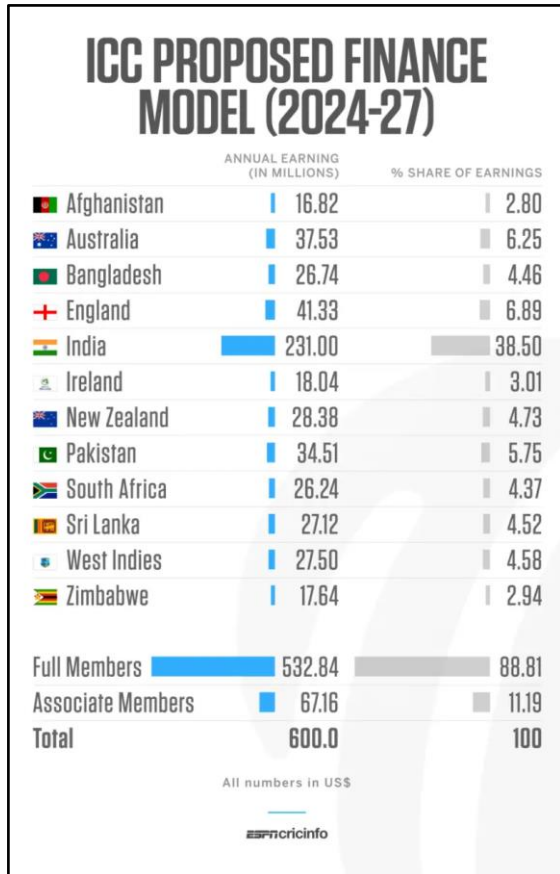
¹¹Revenue Distribution Model. (n.d.). <https://www.sportspro.com/news/icc-revenue-distribution-model-associate-members-bcci/>

¹²Associate Members Unhappy with ICC over Proposed Revenue Distribution Model. (n.d.). <https://www.sportcal.com/media/associate-nations-unhappy-with-icc-over-proposed-revenue-distribution/?cf-view>

¹³Flaws in ICC Revenue Distribution Model. (n.d.). Times of India. <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/sports/cricket/news/iccs-revenue-distribution-model-is-flawed-but-no-one-will-challenge-it-michael-atherton/articleshow/100257872.cms>

¹⁴Graeme Smith's Opinion on Revenue-Sharing Model. (n.d.). <https://www.deccanherald.com/sports/cricket/challenge-for-test-cricket-is-revenue-sharing-model-not-scheduling-graeme-smith-2881846>

¹⁵Challenge for Test Cricket. (n.d.). <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/sports/cricket/news/challenge-for-test-cricket-is-revenue-sharing-model-not-scheduling-graeme-smith/articleshow/107453035.cms>



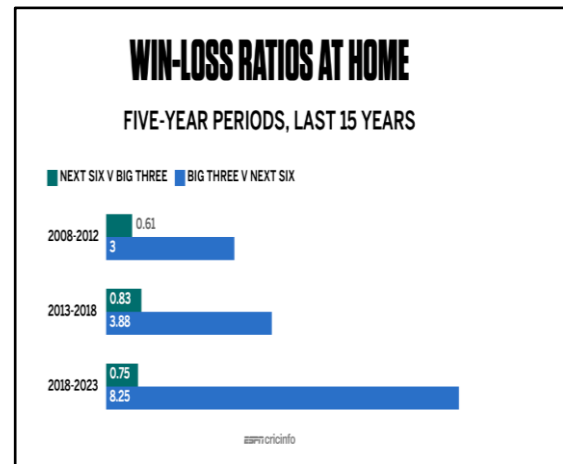
ICC Proposed Revenue Distribution Model
Source: ESPNCricinfo

'Big Three' Dominance

The dominance of the 'Big Three'—India, England, and Australia—has created a divide in Test cricket. These countries play a greater number of Test matches, generate higher profits due to better audience engagement, and have a better winning percentage at home compared to other nations with Test-playing status, which face financial and infrastructural constraints. Over the past 15 years, England, Australia, and India have played approximately 12 Test matches per year—around 50% more than the Next Six Test-playing nations. While the number of matches for the Next Six has not drastically declined, the imbalance in fixtures continues to

limit their opportunities for development and commercial investment in red-ball cricket.¹⁶

Furthermore, Test cricket has evolved into a landscape where the Next Six secure victories in away games against each other but struggle on the home grounds of the Big Three. Meanwhile, the Big Three dominate Tests in the Next Six nations, facing major challenges only from fellow Big Three teams on home soil.



Win-Loss Ratio Comparison for Home Games
Source: ESPNCricinfo

This widening gap is likely to make Test cricket the exclusive domain of the Big Three, which would be detrimental to the growth of cricket in emerging nations and the overall popularity of the format.

Uncertainty Over the Efficacy of Recent Discussions on the Dedicated Fund

The ICC is exploring the introduction of a dedicated fund aimed at supporting nations outside the Big Three to strengthen their Test cricket programs. This initiative, led by Cricket Australia chair Mike Baird and backed by the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB), seeks

¹⁶Big Three Dominance on Test Cricket. (n.d.). <https://www.espncricinfo.com/story/test-cricket-is-increasingly-a-game-of-two-levels-the-big-three-and-the-next-six-1417584>

to create a central fund of around USD 15 million.¹⁷

The goal is to provide financial assistance to smaller cricketing nations, allowing them to offer a minimum match fee of USD 10,000 to players. This is intended to make Test cricket a more viable career option amid the financial allure of franchise leagues, while also easing the financial burden on smaller boards that struggle to afford hosting and touring costs.

However, opinions on the efficacy of this dedicated fund are divided. Proponents argue that this would acknowledge the disparities in Test cricket funding and provide struggling boards with much-needed resources. It could prevent the decline of Tests by incentivising players to participate in Tests rather than shorter formats of the sport. In contrast, sceptics argue that the fund is unlikely to bring meaningful change. Ex-CEO of Cricket West Indies (CWI) Johnny Grave says that a USD 10,000 match fee will not make a difference for teams like the West Indies, where players already receive similar payments.¹⁸ Instead, he emphasizes the need for deeper structural reforms, such as scheduling more three-match series, creating dedicated Test windows, and strengthening 'A' team programs. While the fund represents a shift in mindset from the Big Three, critics believe that financial aid alone cannot resolve the deeper issues affecting

Test cricket's sustainability outside its most profitable markets.

Declining Audience Engagement and Accessibility

Viewership Concerns

The decline of Test cricket is not just a sporting issue but also a reflection of broader societal changes. As attention spans shorten, the slow, strategic nature of Test cricket struggles to compete with the fast-paced excitement of T20 leagues. The rise of digital entertainment and the demand for shorter, easily consumable content have limited Test cricket's appeal primarily to traditionalists. Countries outside the Big Three have particularly suffered, with sparsely populated stadiums.¹⁹

However, former Australian cricketer Tom Moody has pointed out that Test cricket still has a place in the modern game, provided the challenges posed by the rise of franchise leagues and changing audience preferences are effectively addressed.²⁰

Uncertainty Surrounding Broadcaster's Rights

The uncertainty surrounding broadcasters' rights is increasingly challenging the future of Test cricket, as seen by recent events in Pakistan and Australia. In August 2024, the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) struggled to find television broadcast contracts for the home Test series

¹⁷ICC could introduce dedicated fund to reinforce Test cricket outside Big Three. (n.d.). ESPNcricinfo.

<https://www.espnricinfo.com/story/icc-could-introduce-dedicated-fund-to-reinforce-test-cricket-outside-big-three-1448669>

¹⁸CWI CEO Johnny Grave on USD 15 Million Test Fund Proposal. (n.d.). ESPNcricInfo.

<https://www.espnricinfo.com/story/won-t-make-any-difference-outgoing-cwi-ceo-johnny-grave-of-big-3-s-usd-15-million-test-fund-proposal-1449234>

¹⁹Opinion: Opinion | Can Test Cricket Stand The Test Of Time - And The Lure Of T20s? (n.d.). NDTV.

<https://www.ndtv.com/opinion/can-test-cricket-stand-the-test-of-time-and-the-lure-of-t20s-7267780>

²⁰It's a reflection of society. People don't have time': Tom Moody explains alarming decline of Test cricket.

(n.d.). <https://www.hindustantimes.com/cricket/its-a-reflection-of-society-people-dont-have-time-tom-moody-explains-alarming-decline-of-test-cricket-101705732039329.html>

against England. The PCB's initial reserve price of around USD 11.2 million deterred potential broadcasters. It finally settled for a final deal at USD 6-6.5 million, much lower than their initial expectations.²¹ Similarly, in January 2025, Australia's tour of Sri Lanka experienced last-minute broadcast arrangements, with the Seven Network securing rights just 12 days before the first Test.²²

This underscores a broader trend where Test matches struggle to attract lucrative broadcast deals, and only certain fixtures driven by intense country rivalries draw massive audiences. The falling market interest and economic viability of broadcasting Test cricket represent serious challenges to the format's future.

Structural and Scheduling Issues

Structural Issues in the Current Format

Test cricket faces several structural challenges which have a significant impact on its fairness and parity, which include unequal scheduling of matches and the WTC points system. The current WTC cycle does not ensure that all teams play against each other, leading to an imbalance in rankings. For instance, the absence of India-Pakistan fixtures due to political tensions weakens the credibility of the championship.²³

The Points Percentage (PCT) system determines standings by dividing a team's earned points by the maximum points available from matches

played. Originally developed to incentivise consistent performance, disparities in the number of fixtures unfairly penalised teams with heavier schedules. England, for instance, played twice as many matches as South Africa, which increased their exposure to potential point losses. Consequently, despite some commendable performances, they failed to secure a spot in the final.

The disparity extends across the table, with Australia playing 16 and India 18, while teams like Sri Lanka and Bangladesh, with fewer fixtures, benefit from reduced scheduling pressure and remain competitive. Former England captain Kevin Pietersen and other critics argue that this imbalance raises concerns regarding the fairness of the final standings.²⁴

Discussions Regarding a Potential Two-tier System

With the advent of short-format cricket and overseas T20 leagues, Test cricket has taken a backseat in a way. Thus, in a bid to revive the oldest cricket format, the ICC has reportedly made proposals to introduce a two-tier system for the WTC.

In such a structure, the team or teams finishing at the bottom of the top division at the end of a WTC cycle would be relegated to the second tier. Meanwhile, the team or teams topping the second division would earn promotion to the top

²¹Pakistans Home Test Series Broadcast Rights in Limbo. (n.d.).

<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/sports/cricket/news/pakistans-home-test-series-broadcast-rights-in-limbo-amid-drying-market-interest-report/articleshow/112767769.cms>

²²Seven secures rights for Australia's tour of Sri Lanka. (n.d.). ESPNcricinfo. <https://www.espncricinfo.com/story/seven-secures-rights-for-australia-s-tour-of-sri-lanka-1469354>

²³Hindustan Times. (2024, February 14). Four-day Tests and WTC revamp under ICC consideration. <https://www.hindustantimes.com/cricket/fourday-tests-a-possibility-two-tier-system-could-shake-up-wtc-before-india-vs-england-tests-as-icc-plans-major-revamp-101738498764725.html>

²⁴Times of India. (2025, January 2). Criticising South Africa for World Test Championship Final qualification isn't fair: Kevin Pietersen. <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/sports/cricket/news/criticising-south-africa-for-wtc-final-qualification-isnt-fair-kevin-pietersen/articleshow/116844846.cms>

tier. This system is aimed at creating a more competitive structure in Test cricket.

As per reports, India, Australia, England, South Africa, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and New Zealand could be part of tier one, while West Indies, Bangladesh, Afghanistan, Ireland, and Zimbabwe will be put in the second tier.²⁵

In that scenario, marquee series could take place on a more frequent basis with two Ashes contests every three years as opposed to the current two in four.²⁶

However, this raises significant concerns for tier-two teams. Without playing higher-ranked teams, there is a chance the Full Members in the bottom tier would struggle to improve, and players may be increasingly drawn to franchise leagues. Without top-tier teams playing the lower-ranked sides, it poses a danger to those boards, as they may suffer financially due to reduced TV earnings.²⁷

Limited Windows and Inefficient Workload Management

The current global cricket calendar remains overly congested, leaving players with minimal time to recover between different series. Along with Test matches, players' schedules are often packed with multiple other T20 and franchise

league matches, which have a significant physical and mental strain. Players are required to switch frequently between formats without taking requisite breaks, thereby increasing the risk of strain and burnout.

As a result, players are compelled to prioritize certain formats, forcing teams to rest key players and field weakened squads. Young cricketers are also increasingly confined to just one or two formats, restricting their growth and opportunities for advancement.²⁸

Players being overworked is a critical concern, particularly in Test cricket due to the demanding nature of the format. Several players have reported burnout and overwork due to the taxing schedule, notable examples of whom are Ben Stokes, Glenn Maxwell and Yuvraj Singh.

Player rotation, sufficient rest, identifying specialists for each format, and nurturing a strong second and third tier of players who can step in when needed have become key priorities for National Boards and team managements.²⁹

²⁵Firstpost. (2024). *Two-tier Test cricket system: Why it is needed, possible dangers, and more.*

<https://www.firstpost.com/firstcricket/sports-news/two-tier-test-cricket-system-icc-explainer-why-it-is-needed-possible-danger-and-more-13851028.html>.

²⁶Sky Sports. (2024). *Should Test cricket have two tiers, or would that be terrible for some nations?*

<https://www.skysports.com/cricket/news/12123/13285182/should-test-cricket-have-two-tiers-or-would-that-be-terrible-for-some-nations>.

²⁷ESPNcricinfo Staff. (2016, September 7). *The pros and cons of the proposed two-tier system.* ESPNcricinfo.

<https://www.espn-cricinfo.com/story/the-pros-and-cons-of-the-proposed-two-tier-system-1055125>

²⁸WION News. (2023, January). *After Stokes, Buttler slams the hectic cricketing calendar.*

<https://www.wionews.com/sports/after-stokes-buttler-slams-the-hectic-cricketing-calendar-556980>.

²⁹Dasgupta, A. (2021, November 21). *The immense workload of international cricket.* The Times of India.

<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/blogs/a-good-sport/lets-face-it-the-international-cricket-workload-is-immense/>.

Inclusivity Barriers and Inadequate Representation

Limitations for Associate Members

Associate Members are the governing body for cricket of a country recognised by the ICC, countries associated for cricket purposes, or a geographical area, which does not qualify as a Full Member but where cricket is firmly established and organised.³⁰ In International Test Cricket, only Full Members of the ICC are eligible to play Test matches. For an Associate Member to gain Full Member status, they must meet several criteria, such as consistent performance, a well-established domestic cricket structure, adherence to financial and governance standards, and the organization of development programs.³¹

Associate members often struggle financially to accommodate Test cricket, in particular with player salaries and infrastructure.³² Hosting a Test series can be financially draining, making it challenging for smaller nations to invest in this format. Moreover, these nations are concerned that the proposed revenue distribution model, which largely favours cricket's dominant boards, could impede the sport's growth and sustainability.

Given the strict eligibility criteria, and the inherent constraints which the associate members have, they face very limited opportunities to play Test cricket matches at all, and instead focus on and invest in limited-overs formats of cricket instead.

Their perseverance is reflected in ICC tournaments, where teams like the Netherlands and Scotland have demonstrated their ability to compete with established cricketing nations when given the necessary support.

Insufficient Support for Women's Test Cricket

Greg Barclay, the former chair of the International Cricket Council, cautioned fans to expect a decline in the number of Test matches in the coming years and said women's Tests will not be part of the landscape moving forward to any real extent.

A total of 143 women's Tests have been played in the format's 88-year history but only five since 2015, and only once since 2007 has a team other than England, India and Australia competed in one. With the sport's focus increasingly trained on shorter formats, Barclay does not expect a scheduling surge.³³ This decline in women's Test cricket raises concerns about its long-term viability, emphasizing the need for greater commitment from governing bodies to preserve and promote the format.

³⁰About ICC Cricket Members | International Cricket Council. (n.d.). About ICC Cricket | International Cricket Council. <https://www.icc-cricket.com/about/members/about-our-members>

³¹ESPNcricinfo. (n.d.). ICC Test rankings. ESPNcricinfo. <https://www.espn-cricinfo.com/ci-icc/content/page/300901.html>.

³²Lavalette, T. (2021, February 14). *Struggling Test nations plea for more funding and support to safeguard cricket's long format*. Forbes. <https://www.forbes.com/sites/tristanlavalette/2021/02/14/struggling-test-nations-plea-for-more-funding-and-support-to-safeguard-cricket's-long-format/>.

³³Liew, J. (2022, June 3). *Women's Test matches not part of future landscape, says ICC chief*. The Guardian. <https://www.theguardian.com/sport/2022/jun/03/womens-test-matches-not-part-of-future-landscape-says-icc-chief-cricket>.

Furthermore, women in cricket experience marginalization and misogyny, with the women's game often treated as subordinate to the men's game. The England Women's team has yet to play a Test Match at Lord's, with their first opportunity scheduled for 2026³⁴—a milestone, yet one that highlights the prolonged wait for such recognition.

Additionally, the pay disparity between male and female cricketers has long been a concern, with top women players earning significantly less than their male counterparts. A report highlighted the need for a fundamental overhaul of the professional women players' pay structure and equal representation in cricket's governance structures.³⁵

However, a positive development came in 2022 when the BCCI announced equal match fees for India's men's and women's teams, ensuring parity in per-match earnings across formats.³⁶ Despite this progress, several challenges remain, including disparities in central contracts, prize money, and overall investment in women's cricket.

CASE STUDY

Introduction of Pink-Ball Tests

Background

In the light of recent years, the decline in standards of the quality of test cricket viewership, with regards to the mere scarcity of enthusiasm amongst fans has led to the introduction of Pink-

Ball tests. Admittedly, Australia being one of the only nations adapting to it, Pink-Ball tests have been under speculation over the course of its introduction, dating back to the early 2000s.

The said idea was engendered after an analysis of the trends as seen in White-Ball cricket. The T-20 and One Day International (ODI) Formats boasted a hefty viewership and peaked its engagement during primetime, which was post-sundown. An idea was evinced amongst the media and myriads of cricket enthusiasts, to witness Test cricket under the lights. This very idea urged ICC to undertake actions to fulfil the demands that modern-day cricket called for.

Challenges

The introduction to Pink-Ball Tests led to major progressive problems, involving constructive criticism from fans and technical roadblocks which delve deep into the mechanism of cricket. The given ball, for a Test cricket match, involves a red ball made of high-quality leather, for it to sustain the wear and tear it would endure for the course of the 90 overs. Furthermore, it is red in colour to improve its visibility for Test matches, unlike the usual white ball we see in other forms of cricket, which is discreetly used for better visibility under floodlights.³⁷

Subsequently, ideas for this included an enhanced version of the white ball to last the entirety of the 80 overs with the players wearing the coloured kits. However, this proposition was soon dismissed communally as it was distinct

³⁴Historic first Women's Test match in 2026 at Lord's | Lord's. (n.d.). Lord's Cricket Ground.

<https://www.lords.org/lords/news-stories/historic-first-women-s-test-match-in-2026-at-lord>

³⁵Gender Disparity. (n.d.). <https://timesofabetterindia.timesgroup.com/stories-of-a-changing-india/hitting-gender-disparity-for-six-bcci-announces-equal-pay-for-men-and-women#:~:text=The%20match%20fee%20for%20both,same%20as%20their%20male%20counterparts>.

³⁶15th BCCI Apex Council meeting. (n.d.). BCCI. <https://www.bcci.tv/articles/2022/news/55555940/15th-bcci-apex-council-meeting-bcci-implements-pay-equity-policy-for-women-cricketers?type=Latest>

³⁷History of Pink Ball Cricket. (n.d.). ESPNcricInfo. <https://www.espnricinfo.com/story/a-brief-history-of-pink-ball-cricket-1207107>

from the idea of traditional cricket, undermining and affecting the sanctity of test cricket as a whole.

Moreover, the overarching framework which was being constituted, faced numerous rebuttals from active players then. Upon this rejection of idea, subsequently the board was compelled to dismiss such ideas after refusal from players to partake in such competitions.

Breakthroughs

Over the course of the past decade, the global stance with respect to Pink-Ball test cricket has had drastic changes, which was a consequent response to the contrasting and effective analysis of the game pragmatically.

In essence, the first major breakthrough in Pink-Ball tests was soon marked, when a Pink-Ball Test was played in Adelaide post sundown, wherein Australia emerged victorious over New Zealand, in November 2015.

Additionally, Australia upon embracing the novel idea of adapting the idea of “Pink Ball Cricket”, have witnessed conservatively very quantifiable viewership records.

Ever since, the other nations have gradually accepted the concept of Pink-Ball tests after a fair share of active discussions amongst the governing bodies of their respective nations.

Contrasting Beliefs

Resonating with the beliefs of myriads, the concept of a test match being played in the night often was recognised as an experiment much closer to be an ostentatious fad, a gimmicky concept indeed to engage the viewers and to

keep the sport a rather more enjoyable experience by making it more memorable.

On the contrary, an archetypal example could include the Border-Gavaskar Trophy, which spoke volumes for the fact that the originality and individuality of test cricket, in a fresher Pink-Ball format could be marketed in a much more effective way.³⁸

Pink-Ball tests are till date often recognised to be rather favourable to the Australian contingent, who have adopted and embraced this concept entirely. Subsequently this poses a huge reason for lack of participation from other nations in Pink-Ball match-ups as it sets up a premise for claims suggesting these fixtures to be “unfair”.³⁹

Neglect of Women in Test Cricket

Background

Over the past decade, there has been consistent and considerable growth in the popularity of Women's cricket, especially in limited over formats. Upon this surge in viewership, the deteriorating state of the fan-following for Test cricket as a whole has etched Women's sport in its entirety in terms of Test Cricket.

The idea of Women's test cricket was conservatively quoted to be one of the pillars for preserving the very sanctity of the sport, with respect to the sport and its quality, as suggested by the Women's Cricket Association of India (WCAI).

In 2005, a merger took place between ICC and International Women's Cricket Council (IWCC), which unified the powers, transitioning ICC to be the governing body of cricket globally in all of its

³⁸Pink ball test: Are they required?. Times of India Blog. (2024, December 10).
<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/blogs/blockhole/pink-ball-test-are-they-required/>

³⁹MAJUMDAR, B., & Mukeri, Z. (n.d.). Is pink ball Test a failed experiment? The Economic Times.
<https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/sports/is-pink-ball-test-a-failed-experiment/articleshow/116085053.cms?from=mdr>

forms. Moreover, 5 years before this merger, there was a survey conducted by the IWCC. The results of the survey incited the call for all nations urging for a fair combination of Test cricket and One Day cricket.⁴⁰

Challenges

The enthusiasm of the players kept uplifting the spirits of the sport. The players were always found to be under the crosshairs for media scrutiny, especially with only one game a year being played, affecting their morality in terms of the sport's climate socially.⁴¹

Another factor which continues to be a pressing matter in terms of gender imbalance in sport globally, both domestically and internationally, is inadequate funding towards the Women's faction. This unevenness in funding consequently leads to lesser opportunities for Women's cricket.

This in turn reflects upon the added limitations to the given ambit of Women's sports in general. This reiterates the unfair and limited media coverage being scarcely granted to Women's Test cricket, or women's sports generally. A relatively lower media coverage further caps the ambit of women's Test cricket in this economy, deterring their chances at sponsorships or mere media engagement.⁴²

Reforms

In order to cater to the diminishing demands of Women's test cricket, ICC along with England & Wales Cricket Board (ECB) and Cricket Australia have allied to bring reforms to the infrastructure of domestic cricket, in order to lay an omnipresent foundation globally to reinforce the strength and legacy of Test cricket.⁴³

A fresh reiteration to the pre-existing format to the play of cricket involved an improved frequency of scheduling such games. Scheduling abundant breaks between different formats of play, including T20 and ODI formats, adhering to the workload management of players allows for the sport to be rather more enjoyable while portraying different formats being played improving the quality of gameplay for Women's cricket amicably resolved numerous nuances.

Another integral aspect of Test cricket, Ashes, illustrates the legacy and rivalry between the 2 teams, speaks volumes for the build-up and story behind the two teams set standards for Test cricket between the 2 teams, making it an ideal storyline to entice the viewers. Consequently, Women's Ashes was introduced in order to elevate the standards of Test Cricket and not limit it just to the male aspect.⁴⁴

⁴⁰The case for women's Test cricket. (n.d.). <https://www.thecricketmonthly.com/story/963911/the-case-for-women-s-tests>

⁴¹Women's cricket. (n.d.). <https://www.oxfordreference.com/display/10.1093/oi/authority.20110803124504204#:~:text=The%20IWCC%20merged%20with%20the,a%20final%20against%20New%20Zealand>

⁴²Gender Unevenness in Sports. (n.d.). https://www.researchgate.net/publication/326173583_Gender_unevenness_in_the_sports_pages_of_newspapers_A_case_study_based_on_Indian_womens_cricket_team

⁴³New Plan to Drive Growth in Women and Girls' Cricket. (n.d.). Cricket Australia. <https://www.cricket.com.au/news/3990032/new-plan-to-drive-growth-in-women-and-girls-cricket>

⁴⁴Pegan, M., & Smyth, R. (n.d.). Women's Ashes: Australia v England one-off cricket Test, day one – as it happened. The Guardian. <https://www.theguardian.com/sport/live/2025/jan/30/womens-ashes-australia-vs-england-test-day-one-live-blog-updates-scores-results-start-time-mcg-melbourne>

Furthermore, to alleviate the efforts to make Women's Test cricket successful, the introduction to the Women's Test Championship (2022-2025) has been attempting to revive the purity of Test cricket amongst women and mitigate any gender-biased beliefs in the global sports sector.⁴⁵

Scheduling Clash: IPL Auction vs. Border-Gavaskar Trophy

Background

The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) was criticised for scheduling the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2025 Mega Auction during the opening Test match of the Border-Gavaskar Trophy (BGT) between India and Australia.⁴⁶ The scheduling conflict meant that several key Australian cricket personalities, including Ricky Ponting, had to split their commitments between the two events.

Challenges

The Indian Premier League auction, scheduled for 24 and 25 November 2024 in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, saw Ponting (head coach of Punjab Kings), Langer (coach of Lucknow Super Giants), and Vettori (coach of Sunrisers Hyderabad) absent from significant portions of the Perth Test. Ponting and Langer were available only for the opening day of commentary with Channel Seven before flying out for the auction. It is believed that the absence of key coaches could

have been one of the factors for the Australian team's defeat to India by 295 runs in Perth.

Ricky Ponting expressed his frustration over the scheduling conflict. He stated that it was the worst possible case scenario for him and Justin Langer. He mentioned that leading to the auction, they had anticipated that it would be scheduled in the gap between the Test matches. He further said that if the overlap had been avoided, the added pressure would have been taken off the players from both teams, as many of them were in the auction pool.⁴⁷

The major criticism was that the timing was puzzling, as there was enough break between the 1st and 2nd tests to accommodate the auction without any clash. Ponting also speculated about why the dates had been chosen, suggesting that it might have been related to the game. It was suggested that the auction was started on air almost immediately after the end of play, so it might have been related to the broadcast and boosting viewership, which attracted 22.8 million viewers, marking a 29% increase compared to the previous year.⁴⁸

Scheduling Conflicts with the SA20 League

Background

In January 2025, the SA20 league began when the men's Proteas team was scheduled to play New Zealand in a two-match Test series. However, for Cricket South Africa (CSA) to be financially

⁴⁵Championship [W] Points Table | Championship [W] Standings | Championship [W] Ranking. (n.d.). ESPNcricinfo. <https://www.espncricinfo.com/series/icc-women-s-championship-2022-23-2025-1308225/points-table-standings>

⁴⁶IPL Auction 2024 sets new viewership records with 23 million viewers. (n.d.). Economic Times. <https://www.thecricketmonthly.com/story/963911/the-case-for-women-s-tests>

⁴⁷IPL Auction vs BGT: Ricky Ponting lambasts BCCI's "worst-ever" decision for clashing two mega events. (n.d.). <https://www.insidesport.in/cricket/ipl-auction-vs-bgt-ricky-ponting-lambasts-bccis-worst-ever-decision-for-clashing-two-mega-events/>

⁴⁸Ricky Ponting not happy with IPL auction clash with Perth Test: 'Worst scenario'. (n.d.). <https://www.indiatoday.in/sports/story/cricket-ricky-ponting-not-happy-with-ipl-auction-clash-with-perth-test-2636271-2024-11-20>

successful it required that all their top players be contracted to play in the T20 competition.

CSA had stated their case to the ICC, but the Test series remained on the schedule and the Proteas sent an under-strength squad to New Zealand. The Proteas were subsequently soundly beaten in the series, while many criticized SA for sending the inexperienced team over for the Test series.

Challenges

Former Australia captain Steve Waugh said South Africa's decision to send a shadow side to New Zealand for a test tour while their top players take part in a domestic T20 tournament shows the longest format of the game is under threat.⁴⁹

Cricket South Africa (CSA) named seven uncapped players, including skipper Neil Brand, for the two-test tour of New Zealand, which overlapped with the second edition of the SA20 scheduled to commence from Jan 10.

Waugh said the governing International Cricket Council (ICC) and other administrators should step in to protect test cricket. He told the Sydney Morning Herald newspaper that it was obvious they did not care. He stated that if he were New Zealand, the series would not even be played. He questioned why it was even being played when New Zealand cricket was being shown a lack of respect. He further said that if the ICC or someone did not step in shortly, then Test cricket would not remain Test cricket because the best players were not being tested against.

The CSA cancelled a tour of Australia scheduled early last year to ensure the presence of their top players in the inaugural edition of the SA20, which is bankrolled by the Indian Premier League franchises. Australia captain Pat Cummins hoped South Africa's decision did not signal a drift away from test cricket.

Pakistan captain Shan Masood said the situation could have been avoided by better scheduling. The batter said that all the best sides had to play for the World Test Championship, so it was a pity that a full-strength squad was not being sent by South Africa. He expressed hope that, somewhere down the line, schedules could be made in a certain way where the strongest elevens were seen playing Test cricket.

Star South African pacer Kagiso Rabada stated that it was a planning issue and was related to what was happening at the higher level, specifically with CSA. He explained that it was basically a double booking.⁵⁰

The presence of star South African players was considered important for the success of the young SA20 league, and as a result, Test cricket became the casualty. He also confirmed that at the end of the day, a choice was not really given to even go to New Zealand because of the importance of the SA20. It was compared to shooting oneself in the foot by the 28-year-old, who considers Test cricket to be the number one format of the game. Adding to it he stated cricket comes from Test cricket and that, from his perspective, it is the best format all great players who play all formats would say that Test cricket is

⁴⁹Waugh slams S Africa for prioritising domestic T20 tournament over NZ tests. (n.d.).

<https://www.reuters.com/sports/cricket/waugh-slams-s-africa-prioritising-domestic-t20-tournament-over-nz-tests-2024-01-02/>

⁵⁰Rabada on SA20-Test scheduling clash: 'It is like shooting yourself in the foot'. (n.d.). ESPNcricinfo.

<https://www.espn.cricinfo.com/story/kagiso-rabada-on-sa20-clash-with-south-africa-s-test-tour-of-new-zealand-it-is-like-shooting-yourself-in-the-foot-1427739#>

their favourite format, and the same was said to be true for him as well.

The scheduling conflict between SA20 and Test cricket posed various challenges, impacting player availability and team performance. However, in January 2025, the third edition of the tournament commenced without overlapping with Test matches, marking a significant step toward better coordination.⁵¹

CONCLUSION

Test cricket has illustrated its true colours through the omnipotent camaraderie it has boasted over many decades. It emphasizes

tradition, seeks dedication from its players, and with every fixture, evinces a story of its own.

While Test cricket remains the foundation of the sport, it has faced numerous challenges with the rise of shorter formats, leading to shifting audience preferences and a decline in mainstream appeal.

However, it continues to be respected for its strategic depth, rich history, unwavering competitive spirit and the unique test of skill and endurance it offers to players. Significant measures are needed in order to ensure that the legacy of Test cricket is upheld and strengthened.

QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER

1. What strategies can be implemented to enhance the prominence of Test cricket among fans in nations beyond the Big Three?
2. How can financial sustainability be ensured to incentivize players to prioritize Test cricket over T20 leagues, despite the existing financial disparity?
3. What regulatory and structural measures can be introduced to ensure effective workload management for players while safeguarding longevity and maintaining competitiveness in Test cricket?
4. What institutional reforms can be established to create a structured pathway for associate nations to attain Test status?
5. What policy frameworks can be enacted to ensure women's Test cricket becomes a regular and sustainable component of the international cricket calendar?

⁵¹Sherman, M. (n.d.). SA20 begins without any scheduling conflicts in 2025, and that's a relief. IOL.
<https://www.iol.co.za/sport/cricket/proteas/sa20-begins-without-any-scheduling-conflicts-in-2025-and-thats-a-relief-7ffb3454-9f4e-4381-9053-694960e95716>